

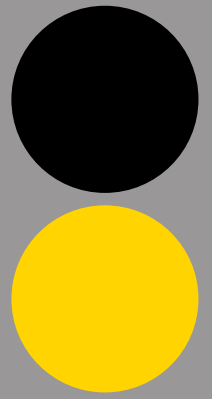


EXPAND YOUR WORLD

GERMAN

LEVEL 1

LESSON 2



Vocab

the house	das Haus
the dog	der Hund
the woman	die Frau
the man	der Mann
the cat	die Katze
the book	das Buch
to understand	verstehen

Grammar

Welcome to your next lesson of German! In the last lesson, we covered a good bit about verbs. In this lesson, we're going to change gears and learn about nouns. A **noun** is a word that is a person, place, thing, or idea. Let's learn a little bit about German nouns.

Noun Gender

Most languages in the world group their nouns into grammatical categories called **noun genders**. Modern-day English does not have this same categorization, so this concept is often a bit odd for English speakers.

In German, there are three noun genders: masculine, feminine, & neuter. All nouns in German are categorized into one of these genders. Nouns that describe humans will most often match the true gender of the word. For example, the word for “man” in German is masculine, and the word for “woman” is feminine.

Examples of masculine nouns: *Hund (dog)*, *Tisch (table)*, *Computer (computer)*

Examples of feminine nouns: *Frau (woman)*, *Tochter (daughter)*

Sometimes, however, this is not the case due to other grammatical rules. For example, the word “girl” in German is “Mädchen”. This word is actually a neuter noun because all nouns that end in “-chen” are neuter. So, even though this noun describes a feminine person, it is grammatically a neuter noun.

All other non-human nouns can be any of the three genders, and it doesn't always make logical sense. For example, the word for “book” in German is a neuter noun, but the word for “table” is a masculine noun. This doesn't mean that a table is a manly object; this is simply a grammatical categorization.

Examples of masculine nouns: *Mann (man)*, *Sohn (son)*, *Junge (boy)*

Examples of feminine nouns: *Katze (cat)*, *Lampe (lamp)*, *Milch (milk)*

Examples of neuter nouns: *Haus (house)*, *Buch (book)*, *Auto (car)*

So how can you know what gender a noun is in German? Well, unfortunately, the answer is that you simply need to memorize each noun's gender. There are many different endings that tend to belong to one gender or the other, but the simplest way to learn a noun's gender is to learn it when you learn the noun.

The easiest way to do this is to learn the article with the noun! What’s an article? **Articles** are small words in languages that indicate a certain level of specificity of a noun.

Basic articles in English: *the, a, an*

Articles are either definite (the) or indefinite (a/an). In German, unfortunately, there are many ways to say “the” and “a/an”! It all depends on the noun’s gender and case (we’ll cover this in a second). Each noun gender uses its own articles. Let’s look at the most basic articles in German for each gender:

The Basic Articles		
GENDER	THE	A / AN
masculine	der	ein
neuter	das	
feminine	die	eine

So, if we look at the definite articles (the), we can see each gender has a special word for “the” in German. Masculine nouns use “der,” neuter nouns use “das,” and feminine nouns use “die.” In our vocab list, you can see your vocab nouns have one of these articles listed with them.

MASCULINE	the man	der Mann
	the dog	der Hund
NEUTER	the house	das Haus
	the book	das Buch
FEMININE	the woman	die Frau
	the cat	die Katze

This is how you can learn which gender a noun belongs to! When you learn the noun, learn how to say the correct “the” (definite article) with it. If you’re learning a word outside this course, you can simply look it up in the dictionary to find out which gender. Most dictionaries have a way to indicate gender. Some will use “m.”, “f.”, & “n.” to designate, or something similar. You can also use translators by typing “the” plus the noun, and they’ll usually give the correct article.

Once you know the gender, you’ll be able to use the noun correctly. For example, you’ll know how to say the correct “a” with the noun. Notice you’ve learned two different ways to say “a/an”: ein & eine. Masculine & neuter words use “ein”, but feminine words use “eine”.

Since the word “die Katze” uses “die”, we know it’s feminine. Since we know it’s feminine, we can also know that if we want to say “a cat,” we simply say “eine Katze.” Let’s see some example sentences!

Die Katze schläft.

The cat is sleeping.

Eine Katze schläft.

A cat is sleeping.

Der Mann tanzt.

The man is dancing.

Ein Mann tanzt.

A man is dancing.

Das Haus ist klein.

The house is small.

The Nominative & Accusative Cases

Now that you've learned about noun genders, it's time to learn about noun cases. Noun cases are important concepts to learn about when learning German, but many people find them to be very daunting. It's important to keep an open mind and not get hung up on this concept! They're much simpler than many people are taught.

A **noun case** is the role of the noun in the sentence. In English, we tend to describe noun role's using words like subject & object. In German, and many other languages in the world, noun's roles are defined by noun cases. Some languages have many noun cases, but German only has four!

In this lesson, we are only going to learn the first two noun cases: the nominative case & the accusative case. Don't let the large words scare you; we will break them down for you.

Unlike genders, nouns don't "belong" to a case. Instead, nouns can be used in each case depending on its role in the sentence. Why are noun cases important? Well, nouns, articles, and other words can actually change form when put into different cases!

The Nominative Case

A noun is considered to be in the nominative case when it is used as the subject of the verb. This is the main function of the nominative case. In English, this is the noun that usually precedes the verb. The good news is that the nominative case is also the default case of all nouns. This means when you learn a noun in the dictionary, or in your vocab list, you learn it in its nominative case form.

Examples of the subject in English: ***The man*** is dancing. / ***The woman*** sleeps.

The nominative case is also used as the object of the verb "to be". Remember, the verb "to be" in English is conjugated as "am, is, are" in the present tense.

Examples of object of "to be" in English: That is **a book**. / He is **a man**.

There are the two most common instances of the nominative case. The articles you learned earlier are considered the "nominative articles."

The Nominative Case Articles

GENDER	THE	A / AN
masculine	der	ein
neuter	das	
feminine	die	eine

The Accusative Case

A noun is considered to be in the accusative case when it is used as the direct object of most verbs. This is the main function of the accusative case. This means it is directly affected by the verb or it's the thing being done. In English, this is usually the noun that follows the verb.

Examples of the direct object in English: *I understand **the man**.* / *I see **a book**.*

The nominative case is also used as the object of certain prepositions. We will learn about these in a later lesson.

There are the two most common instances of the accusative case. So how does a noun change when used in the accusative case? The main thing that changes is its article. Fortunately, the feminine and neuter nouns have no change in the accusative case in comparison to the nominative case. The masculine nouns, however, get a new set of articles. Let's take a look.

The Accusative Case Articles

GENDER	THE	A / AN
masculine	den	einen
neuter	das	ein
feminine	die	eine

We can simplify these two charts into one chart.

Definite Articles (THE)			
	masculine	neuter	feminine
Nominative	der	das	die
Accusative	den		
Indefinite Articles (A/AN)			
	masculine	neuter	feminine
Nominative	ein	ein	eine
Accusative	einen		

Do you remember the subject pronouns you learned in the previous lesson? Well, these are also better known as the **Nominative Case Pronouns**! Later, you'll learn about the Accusative Case Pronouns, too.

So let's see some example sentences using our two different cases. We will put all nominative case nouns & pronouns in GREEN and all accusative case pronouns in BLUE.

Ich tanze.
I am dancing.

Verstehst du die Frau?
Do you understand the woman?

Ich verstehe den Mann nicht.

I don't understand the man.

Wir gehen!

We are going!

Die Frau und der Mann schlafen.

The woman and the man are sleeping.

Das Mädchen schläft, aber der Mann schläft nicht.

The girl is sleeping, but the man isn't sleeping.

Er sieht das Haus.

He sees the house.

Sie sieht einen Hund.

She sees a dog.

That's the end of this lesson! Starting with the next lesson, we will start having reading sections in each lesson. Congratulations on completing your second lesson of German!